

On Fear of Death

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A year ago exactly, I merited to take part in Operation Cast Lead, which at the time was also known as the "Gaza War." True, today we know the results of the operation, and, thank God, it can be defined as a military success, with a relatively small number of casualties (as terrible as it is to "measure" human lives at all) relative to our forces. But the feeling that preceded the ground entry of the infantry brigades into Gaza, both among the population on the home front and among the soldiers themselves, was one of worry and apprehension. The talk of the army commanders that I happened to hear during that stretch of time, as we waited for the various stages of the operation, was full of resolve and courage, but, at the same time, in order not to mislead and in order to remain committed to "realism," it carried a full awareness of the heavy price that would apparently be exacted from us in the course of the fighting. This introduction seemed necessary to me because today, in hindsight, this experience of Cast Lead no longer seems so frightening to me, but at the time, the fear was shared by many.

I have not come to deal with my own personal experience of the fear of death and how I coped with it, mainly because I do not have much to say on the subject from the personal angle; the coping is emotional, and not only is it hard to translate into words, but I do not see any benefit in doing so — nothing significant can be said on the cognitive plane, except that one must cope. What is true, though, is that this unusual event led me to think general thoughts about the place of the fear of death in our lives and in our souls, and it is these I have come to share.

From Rav Kook's treatment of the fear of death (Orot Ha-Kodesh II, pp. 380–384),^[1] we tend to remember mainly that the fear of death is a false fear, an illusion. And indeed, at the foundation of the experience there is a non-negligible element of illusion. This illusion stems from an identification of "life" with "existence" — that is, the soul feels that with the end of its life on earth, it will be utterly lost and will cease to exist at all. Our faith in the survival of the soul, and in the existence of "two worlds," separates existence from life, since even the dead exist in the World to Come. The more the recognition that separates and distinguishes between spirit and body is sharpened within us, and the more deeply we come to believe that even after death we do not arrive at a state of nullification, but only of a separation from the body and from earthliness and a passage to a spiritual life, the more the terrifying fear of death, which drains a person of the very desire for life, softens. The alarm and horror at the plundering of existence and the nullification of the soul's reality weaken, and even disappear, the more a person becomes aware of the distinctness of his spiritual selfhood and of the eternity of psychic existence.

Nevertheless, I feel that so weighty an existential phenomenon cannot be explained by a rationale claiming that, in fact, the experience in question is rootless, without any real substance, and that, at bottom, it is all illusion and a falsehood with no legs to stand on. Fear of death is something normal human beings will never be entirely freed of, and if so, my thoughts led me toward a further direction of thought, different from the attempt to diminish, soften and sweeten the bitter pill, since the bitterness and dreadfulness of death will always remain, to some degree, what they are, and one must also stand before this fact and contain it within the spiritual world.

If we indeed believe that death is only the release of the soul from the bonds of physicality, from the straits of finitude and the shackles of limited reality, what is the true, enduring root that exists within the fear of death? Does it truly stem only from the external sides of the self, which fail to free themselves from the bonds of imagination and habit and are forced to identify personal selfhood (the "I") with the body and with life?

My sense is that this is not so. Indeed, even the soul feels pain at the fear of death, though in a less imaginative and destructive form, yet still in a hard and tormenting way. I feel it is correct to say that the soul truly loves life. It loves life for its very earthliness, and not despite the earthliness but precisely because of it as well; and I do not speak only of the love of life because of the spiritual realities present within it, or because of all the kinds of "foretaste of the World to Come" already present in our lives, but precisely of the love of life for its own intrinsic character, bound up with earthliness.

To explain this, let me begin from a different direction. The hedonistic worldview and way of life stem from the conception that pleasure is what ought to stand at the center of life, since it is the purpose of life — man was created for nothing but pleasure. On the face of it, if we look, for example, at the words of the Ramchal at the opening of his book *Mesillat Yesharim*, we find an identical formulation — "that man was created for nothing but to delight in God and to enjoy the splendor of His Shekhinah, for this is the true delight and the greatest of all pleasures that can be found." And indeed these words sit well with the heart, and there is something instinctive in the thought that pleasure is the matter aimed at in all our wills and in all our deeds. Where does the error lie, or the difference, between this thought and the words of the Ramchal?

The difference lies again in the distinction stated above between life and existence. Pleasure is indeed the most foundational point in man's being; it is what Kabbalah calls "Keter," which is the root of the will. Hence the very pursuit of pleasure as the supreme point of existence is not negative — it is true. Except that, in our faith, when life ceases, man does not cease to be, but only ceases to live. Life is movement, flow; what represents, in the Torah, the living soul is the blood, a system of unceasing dynamism. The purpose of life, its essence and its meaning, are activity, repair, elevation and beneficial influence — "one hour of repentance and good deeds in this world is better than all the life of the World to Come." This is a world of labor and doing, in which, too, there is pleasure — perhaps the supreme pleasure of all. After death comes the hour of rest and delight, a day that is wholly Sabbath, and then the essence of existence changes from active-building to passive-delighting —

"one hour of tranquility of spirit in the World to Come is better than all the life of this world."

We have learned, then, that the essence of life and its principal character are "repentance and good deeds." That very dynamism, the earthly capacity to labor, to improve, to advance, to be refined, to be elevated, is the root of the soul's love of life, since this is what it was made for, this is what man was created for. And the World to Come that follows death, with all its goodness and delight, does not contain the element of activity and self-improvement that lies at the heart of the soul's desire. We love life because it is the very purpose of the creation of all that exists, including ourselves; the fear of death, at its soul-root, comes from the person's dread that he has not managed to fulfill his very purpose, which is found in the stormy meeting between matter and spirit, between heaven and earth, and in the elevation of the whole of being by force of that free, individual spark. The dread of death is indeed a dread of cessation, but not an imagined cessation of ontological existence, but a true cessation — the missing of the very heart of existence and the reason for its coming-into-being.

It seems that such an outlook on this foundational and primal life-force of the fear of death is important not only from the theoretical side but also from the existential one. When we stand close to death, whether this is an encounter with the death of some other, or fear at the approach of our own death, the hatred of death floods us inescapably, repels us, shocks us. If we examine the basic point standing at the root of this psychic phenomenon, at the root of this instinctive repelling force, and remember and internalize that the hatred of death is the love of life, and that the love of life is the soul's deep will to make the most of life, and to act and move and advance and do within it as much as possible — this reflection can sweeten the very feeling of repulsion, disgust and dread into a feeling of acute urgency, into intensive diligence and vigor, and into sharp awareness and sensitivity toward the fulfillment of the meaning of our lives and the purpose of our existence in the time allotted to us upon the earth.

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Notes

1. I do not enter into the teaching of Rav Kook on this subject in depth, mainly because I have not fully plumbed his intent in these passages. My impression is drawn from various people with whom I studied this, and also from further sources that cite these passages and interpret them. This is an impression I have drawn not only from Rav Kook's teaching but from religious approaches to death and to the fear of it in general that I have encountered.